How Made for you chooses

A listener's taste profile and the ranking built on it, generated from FAM's code.

ALGO_VERSION 2026-10-05.1 · fingerprint c528f925841f209f · regenerate with `python tools/algorithm_docs.py`

What Made for you is

The first rail on myFAM, chosen for one listener from two inventories: today's live stories and the evergreen bank.

- Built on every page load, never stored - a pure query over the listener's own event log.
- Trending chooses first, from the world, and Made for you never shows what Trending holds.
- Nothing on the page generates an episode: tiles are a title and an angle, written on tap.

1. The taste profile

Every action is logged with the subjects of what it was about. Each kind of action has a weight.

- A signal halves every 14 days.
- Behaviour is scaled so the strongest subject is 1.0.
- Chosen interests are then added at 2, constant: never decayed, never outvoted, never lowered by a skip. They are the part a listener controls on purpose.
- Impressions (a tile being shown) are never taste.

Signal	Weight	What it is
vibe	2.5	VIBE! on an episode
pick	2.2	A subject picked from a list (the interests page)
mix_add	2	A subject or episode added to one of your mixes
share	2	Sending an episode to someone
save	2	Save for later
search	1.5	Typing (or saying) a question
complete	1.5	Finishing an episode (85% heard)
play	1	Starting an episode
skip	-0.5	Skipping an episode
not_interested	-1.5	Not interested, from a tile's three dots - the tile also leaves your rails

2. A tree, not a list

Subjects live in a category tree with no depth limit: sport > American football > NFL > Bengals.

- The most specific subject an episode is about takes the whole signal.
- Each heading above it takes 0.6x per level (0.6, 0.36, 0.216 ...).
- So a Bengals fan's profile knows the Bengals best, and the NFL and football as a whole too.
- The tree grows from what listeners search; most major-league teams are seeded so one fan's team counts from day one.

3. Scoring a tile

affinity = sum over the tile's tags of (taste x specificity), divided by the square root of the number of tags.

- Specificity: a heading 1.0, a subtag 1.75, a category 1.75 to the power of its depth - so a story on the specific subject beats one on its heading.
- Plus a meaning match (embeddings) where the model is installed.
- x fatigue, x freshness (1 + 1.6 x push, live only), x local 1.5, x engagement (0.6-1.5).
- Kept only above 0.12.

4. What is never offered

Exclusions, applied before or instead of a score.

- Anything the listener has already heard (a moved-on live story comes back as a 'what's new' follow-up).
- A live story that names nothing they follow - only the heading matches, no word they used, no near paraphrase.
- A minor-league game on another continent, unless they follow the team or league.
- Anything Trending or 'What you missed' already holds.

5. Shaping the rail

After scoring, the rail is arranged, not re-ranked.

- Already-written episodes go first, 24 deep.
- At most 2 tiles per heading - strictly.
- Topped up to 4 from evergreen tiles by affinity - never from the live pool.
- A learned re-ranker may reorder what cleared the floor, only if one has been trained and beat the hand order.

6. A brand-new listener

With no actions and no interests, the profile is a prior.

- Headings ranked by what everyone plays, each 0.08 lower than the one above.
- The startup questions lead, a local one first if they gave a town.
- One play, search or chosen interest replaces the prior for good.

Worked example: a Bengals fan

Run through the real `taste` and `_affinity` over the seeded category tree.

Action	Text	Days ago	Weight	After decay
complete	cincinnati bengals injury report	0.5	1.5	1.463
complete	how the bengals rebuilt their offensive line	2	1.5	1.359
complete	bengals playoff chances this season	4	1.5	1.231
search	bengals quarterback contract	1	1.5	1.428
search	nfl trade deadline winners	3	1.5	1.293
play	how do mrna vaccines work	6	1	0.743
skip	college football playoff rankings explained	2	-0.5	-0.453

Chosen interest: **culture** - held constant on top of everything else.

Their profile, as the tree it is:

```
Culture  2.00
Sport  0.41
    American Football  0.45
        NFL  0.84
            Bengals  1.00
    Sports Business  0.26
    Sports Drama  0.24
Health & mind  0.05
    Medicine  0.08
        Vaccines  0.14
```

How six tiles score (affinity, before the multipliers):

Tile	Tags it carries	Affinity
Bengals injury report before Sunday	american football, bengals, nfl, sports	4.559
NFL trade deadline: who won	american football, nfl, sports	2.17
Inside the Oscars race	culture	2
College football playoff picture	american football, college football, football, sports	0.401
Premier League title race	football, premier league, sports	0.152
A new malaria vaccine	health, science	0.035

What changed

2026-10-05.1 (§202)

- Taste is a subject tree: the most specific subject an episode is about takes the whole signal, each heading above it 0.6x per level (Bengals > NFL > American football > sport).
- Chosen interests are constant: added after normalisation at 2, never decayed, never outvoted, never taken below that by a skip. Named subjects from the interests page count as well as the eight facets.
- Weights: search 2 -> 1.5, finish 2 -> 1.5, pick 1.6 -> 2.2.
- New signal: adding something to a mix (mix_add) is worth 2.0.
- Most NFL, NBA, MLB and NHL teams are seeded into the category tree under their leagues, so one fan's team is a subject from their first search. A team whose name is also weather or the news ('Carolina Hurricanes') is left to grow from real sports questions.

2026-09-23.3 (§187)

- Owner's weights: search 2, play 1, finish 2, skip -0.5, save 2, vibe 2.5. Made for you files subjects by field; variety cap is strict; no far minor leagues; market moves on any money taste.

Every constant

Name	Value	Meaning
HALF_LIFE	1209600	Seconds for a signal to lose half its weight
INTEREST_WEIGHT	2	A chosen interest, constant, after normalisation
ANCESTOR_SHARE	0.6	Share of a signal each heading above a subject gets, per level
SUBTAG_WEIGHT	1.75	How much a subtag match counts next to a facet match
CATEGORY_DEPTH_WEIGHT	1.75	Per-level specificity of a grown category (compounds)
FRESHNESS_BOOST	1.6	Live story lift: 1 + this x freshness
LOCAL_BOOST	1.5	Live story naming the listener's city or region
BROAD_MATCH_PENALTY	0	Live story with no sign of interest (0 = excluded)
SEMANTIC_NEAR_COSINE	0.6	Similarity that counts as 'been near' a subject
SUBJECT_DEPTH	2	Tree depth at which a category names a subject
RELEVANCE_FLOOR	0.12	Below this a tile is not a recommendation
FATIGUE_WEIGHT	0.35	Damping per ignored showing
FATIGUE_GRACE	2	Showings before fatigue counts
FATIGUE_FLOOR	0.15	Fatigue never pushes below this
ENGAGEMENT_WEIGHT	1	Strength of the global tap-rate term
ENGAGEMENT_PRIOR	20	Showings before a tile's own tap rate counts
ENGAGEMENT_FLOOR	0.6	Lowest engagement multiplier
ENGAGEMENT_CEILING	1.5	Highest engagement multiplier
SECTION_SIZE	4	Tiles on a rail
MAX_PER_FACET	2	Most tiles from one heading on Made for you
CANDIDATE_FACTOR	3	Candidates per shown tile handed to the variety pass
READY_REACH	24	How deep the rail looks for already-written episodes
STARTUP_PRIOR_STEP	0.08	Cold start: drop per rank of a heading's popularity